

Step 10 Talk Draft — Nightly Inventory

Theme: Step 10, nightly inventory, emotional detachment, self-care, and momentum Target duration: 18–22 minutes at measured pace with pauses Status: Draft 1

Notation guide: - (Pause.) = 2 seconds - (Long Silence.) = 4–5 seconds - (*slow*) = slow down - **bold** = slight emphasis

Tuesday night. 10:17.

The house is quiet except for the sound of the refrigerator kicking on and off in the kitchen.

I'm sitting at the table with a pen in my hand.

Not writing.

Just holding the pen.

(Pause.)

There is a piece of paper in front of me. Clean. Too clean, maybe. A cup of tea has gone cold beside it. The light over the table is a little too bright, the way kitchen lights can be at night when the rest of the house has gone dark.

And I am trying to do something very simple.

Take inventory.

(Pause.)

That sounds simple when you say it in a meeting.

Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it.

There it is.

A sentence.

A beautiful sentence.

But at 10:17 at night, with a pen in your hand and a day behind you, it is not just a sentence.

It is the place where you have to sit still long enough to tell the truth.

(Pause.)

And for people like us, telling the truth is not always the first hard thing.

Sometimes the first hard thing is finding the facts underneath all the feelings.

Because for many of us, feeling and fact got tied together a long time ago.

Somebody did not call back.

Fact.

They are rejecting me.

Not fact.

Somebody disagreed with me.

Fact.

They do not respect me.

Maybe. Maybe not.

I made a mistake.

Fact.

I am a mistake.

No.

(Pause.)

That's the old sickness talking.

That's not inventory.

That's punishment wearing a clean shirt.

(Long Silence.)

I had to learn that.

Slowly.

Because when I first came around this program, if you handed me Step 10 and said, "Look at your day," I knew how to do only one kind of looking.

I knew how to look for what was wrong.

What was wrong with me.

What was wrong with you.

What was wrong with the room.

What was wrong with the coffee.

What was wrong with the weather.

What was wrong with the way somebody looked at me when I walked in.

I could find wrong in anything.

(Pause.)

And I did.

I found it and picked it up and carried it around like proof.

See?

There it is again.

The world is against me.

Or worse.

I am against me.

(Pause.)

That is a terrible way to live.

It is a terrible way to pray.

It is a terrible way to do Step 10.

Because Step 10 is not meant to be a nightly beating.

It is not meant to be the alcoholic sitting down with a stick and saying, "Now let's see how bad I was today."

That's not it.

That may be familiar, but familiar is not the same as spiritual.

(Pause.)

For me, Step 10 had to become a piece of self-care.

That may sound strange to some people.

Self-care.

We hear that word and we think of soft things. Rest. A walk.

A meal. Sleep. A quiet hour.

And those things matter.

They matter more than we sometimes admit.

But there is another kind of self-care.

The kind where I stop letting my head lie to me.

The kind where I sit down and separate what happened from what I made it mean.

(Pause.)

There is a freedom in that.

A real freedom.

Because if I can put the facts on paper, I do not have to live

inside the noise.

(Pause.)

So I sit there.

Pen in hand.

And I ask the old questions.

Was I angry?

Was I fearful?

Was I resentful?

Was I dishonest?

(Pause.)

Those are good questions.

They are necessary questions.

They have saved me from myself many times.

But if I am not careful, those are the only questions I ask.

And if those are the only questions I ask, then I begin to believe that anger, fear, resentment, and dishonesty are the whole story of me.

They are not.

(Long Silence.)

My defects of character are not my identity.

(Pause.)

I am responsible for them.

I must see them.

I must admit them.

I must make amends when they harm another person.

But they are not the deepest truth about who I am.

There is something in us that alcohol could bury, but it could not destroy.

(Pause.)

Already there.

Even on the bad day.

Even on the day when I was sharp with somebody.

Even on the day when I was afraid and tried to control everything within reach.

Even on the day when I wanted credit for something I did quietly and then got resentful because nobody noticed.

Still there.

(Pause.)

So the inventory has to be honest enough to see the defect.

And gentle enough not to make the defect my name.

(Long Silence.)

That took me a long time.

Because the alcoholic mind loves all-or-nothing.

If I was wrong, I am all wrong.

If I made a mistake, everything is ruined.

If I hurt somebody, I should go away and sit in the dark and think about it for three days.

That sounds like humility.

It is not humility.

Sometimes it is just pride turned inside out.

Still about me.

Still staring at me.

Still making me the center of the room.

(Pause.)

Step 10 moves differently.

It does not ask me to live in the mud.

It asks me to notice the mud on my shoes and clean it off
before I track it through the house.

(Pause.)

That is a different thing.

Much different.

When we were wrong, promptly admitted it.

Promptly.

Not after I have built a court case.

Not after I have explained to three people why I was
technically justified.

Not after I have rewritten the story so that I come out
looking a little better.

Promptly.

(Pause.)

That word has saved me a lot of suffering.

Not all of it.

I am still me.

But a lot.

Because when I notice something now, there is a little dial
inside me.

Not a perfect one.

Sometimes it sticks.

Sometimes I pretend I cannot hear it.

But it is there.

(Pause.)

I notice I was sharp.

I notice I was afraid.

I notice I wanted to win more than I wanted to be useful.

I notice I was dishonest, maybe not with my words, but with what I left out.

And then Step 10 calls on the life I have already been given in the earlier steps.

(Pause.)

First, I turn toward God.

Not with a speech.

Sometimes not even with a good prayer.

Sometimes it is just, "Help."

Sometimes it is, "There it is again."

Sometimes it is sitting on the edge of the bed with my shoes still on, looking at the floor.

(Pause.)

Then I tell somebody.

Not because I need a committee.

Because I need air.

The thing that lives in my head gets smaller when it comes out of my mouth.

(Pause.)

I call someone.

Or I say to my sponsor, “I need to tell you what I did.”

Or I sit across from a man in a coffee shop and I stop polishing the sentence.

I just say it.

I was wrong.

I was afraid.

I was trying to control.

I was not honest.

(Pause.)

And then, if I have harmed somebody, I make the amend.

Not the dramatic amend.

Not the one where I explain all the reasons why I acted that way.

Not the one where I say, “I’m sorry you felt hurt.”

No.

That old slippery thing.

(Pause.)

A real amend is simpler than that.

“I was wrong when I said that.”

“I was impatient.”

“I put pressure on you because I was afraid.”

“I owe you an apology.”

“What can I do to make that right?”

(Pause.)

And then this beautiful last movement.

We turn outward.

We help somebody.

Not as a trick.

Not to erase the mistake.

But because self-absorption is a small room, and service opens a window.

(Long Silence.)

That is momentum.

That is Step 10 moving.

Notice.

Pray.

Tell.

Amend.

Help.

(Pause.)

It does not leave me knee-deep in the morass of my mistakes.

It moves me through.

And sometimes through is the miracle.

(Pause.)

I like that word, through.

Because I used to confuse spiritual growth with never making mistakes.

If I were really sober, I would not get angry.

If I were really spiritual, I would not be afraid.

If I had worked the steps properly, I would not have resentment show up again.

(Pause.)

That's nonsense.

That is perfectionism wearing a halo.

(Long Silence.)

The question is not whether a human being will make mistakes.

The question is whether he has a way back.

(Pause.)

Step 10 gives me a way back before I drift too far.

Before the resentment becomes a story.

Before the fear becomes a plan.

Before the dishonesty becomes a lifestyle.

Before the anger becomes my voice.

(Pause.)

That's mercy.

Practical mercy.

The kind you can do with a pen.

(Pause.)

And then there is another part of Step 10 that I love more and more as I get older.

It asks me something larger than, "What did I do wrong?"

It asks me about life.

Was I loving and kind toward all?

(Pause.)

That's a different measurement.

Not softer.

Deeper.

Because I can avoid doing obvious harm and still not be very loving.

I can be technically correct and spiritually cold.

I can be clean on paper and closed in my heart.

(Pause.)

Was I loving and kind toward all?

That question will not let me hide behind being right.

It asks about my tone.

My patience.

My willingness.

The look on my face when someone needed five minutes from me and I had already decided I was too busy.

(Pause.)

And then this question.

Have I stopped fighting anything or anybody?

(Pause.)

That one still finds me.

After all these years, it still finds me.

Because I can stop drinking and still fight.

Fight the day.

Fight the body getting older.

Fight the person who did not behave the way I thought they should.

Fight the traffic.

Fight the computer.

Fight the part of me that needs rest.

Fight God quietly, while telling everyone I am surrendered.

(Pause.)

Have I stopped fighting anything or anybody?

Some nights I can write yes.

Some nights I have to put the pen down for a moment.

(Long Silence.)

And then there is that wonderful question from the book.

What can I pack into the stream of life?

(Pause.)

I love that.

The stream of life.

Not the swamp of self.

Not the courtroom in my head.

The stream of life.

What can I pack into it?

Kindness.

A phone call.

An apology.

A quiet word.

A ride.

A few minutes with someone who is new.

A prayer for someone I would rather be angry with.

A dish washed without making an announcement.

(Pause.)

Small things.

Almost always small things.

But small things change the temperature of a day.

And a changed day becomes a changed life if you let enough of them gather.

(Pause.)

That's what I missed early on.

I thought Step 10 was only a correction tool.

Something to catch the defect.

And it is that.

Thank God it is that.

But it is also a direction tool.

It points me back toward the stream.

Back toward usefulness.

Back toward being a man among other people instead of a man trapped in the weather of his own head.

(Pause.)

I look around meetings sometimes and I see the new people.

I see the way a man sits with his coat still on, like he might have to leave quickly.

I see the woman turning the coffee cup a quarter turn, then another quarter turn, not drinking it.

I see someone laugh a little too fast when nothing is funny.

I know that place.

Not their story.

I do not know their story.

But I know something about the knot inside.

(Pause.)

And I wish I could hand them the whole thing at once.

I wish I could say, "You are going to be more than this fear."

But that is not how it works.

So we give them what was given to us.

One day.

One inventory.

One honest line on a page.

One apology made before the sun goes down on it.

One phone call instead of three hours alone with the story.

(Pause.)

That is how freedom comes for people like us.

Not all at once.

Not usually.

It comes in the small honest movements we make before the old life has time to rebuild itself.

(Long Silence.)

Tonight, if I sit at that kitchen table again, I may still pause before I write.

I may still feel that old pull to make a case against myself.

Or against somebody else.

I may still want to turn a fact into a sentence with a verdict at the end.

(Pause.)

But now there is another way.

I can write the fact.

I can leave the fiction off the page.
I can ask whether I was angry, fearful, resentful, dishonest.
I can ask whether I was loving and kind.
I can ask whether I have stopped fighting.
I can ask what I can pack into the stream of life.
(Pause.)
And then I can get up from the table.
Not perfect.
Not finished.
Just freer than I was when I sat down.
(Long Silence.)
The tea is still cold.
The refrigerator still hums.
The paper is no longer clean.
And the pen is lying beside it.
Not in my fist anymore.
Beside it.

Critic / Advisor Review

Overall score: 87/100 Status: Approved after minor polish

What is working: - Strong Step 10 teaching frame without becoming a lecture. - Clear behavioral process: notice, pray, tell, amend, help. - Good separation of facts from meaning, behavior from identity. - Preserves John's plainspoken recovery voice and uses pauses effectively. - Strong self-care

angle: inventory as freedom rather than punishment.

What needs improvement before final delivery: 1. Add one more personal concrete scene from John's lived experience if available. The kitchen table scene works, but a real remembered room would make this stronger. 2. Consider adding one short example of a specific amend John made or almost avoided. 3. Trim 200–300 words if the delivery pace runs long.

Lines to consider personalizing: - "Tuesday night. 10:17."

Replace with a real time/place if John has one. - "The house is quiet except for the sound of the refrigerator..." Replace with a remembered sound if available. - "I sit across from a man in a coffee shop..." Replace with a sponsor/sponsee scene if John wants more lived texture.